customary rites. By the time he emerged out of prison, in late December 1912, the world was a changed place.

With the Swadeshi movement effectively broken by the wave of repression that his arrest had inaugurated, VOC stepped into a world that he could barely recognize. On his release from prison, VOC's priority was to fend for himself and his family. Relying on public subscriptions and support from friends, especially in South Africa, VOC focussed on writing and publishing, earning a modest income from the sale of his books. Such was his straitened circumstances, that, when Gandhi, on his visit to Madras City in 1915, gave him an early morning appointment, VOC expressed his inability to meet him as 'the tram car, the only vehicle by which I can now afford to go to your place, leaves … [only] after 5:30 in the mornings'.[2] A man who had organized the purchase of two steamers now did not have half a rupee to hail a cart.

After World War I, VOC took part in the rising labour movement. A strong supporter of Tilak, he played his bit in the Home Rule Movement. Tilak's death in 1920, and the attendant rise of Gandhi left him rudderless. The changed political climate shaped by Gandhi was not to his taste. If many of his Swadeshi colleagues gravitated towards Gandhi (Subramania Bharati, Subramania Siva, and Krishnaswamy Sarma) and the Hindu Mahasabha (B.S. Moonje and G.S. Khaparde), he was swayed by neither. Uprooted from his home base in Tirunelveli district, VOC could not flourish in other climes. The Brahmin-dominated Tamilnadu Congress organization also sidelined him. Evidently, he could not get along with a new leadership, which was more keen on political power than on mobilizing the people directly. As the non-Brahmin question acquired a keen edge, following the Non-Brahmin Manifesto (1916) and the emergence of the Justice Party, it was but natural that it would strike a chord in VOC. Periyar's Self-Respect Movement too left its mark on him, as he took on the reactionary elements in his own Vellalar caste.[3] With his scholarly editions of mediaeval commentaries of the ancient grammatical text, *Tholkappiyam* and the book of morals, *Thirukkural*, his contributions to language and literature are also worthy of note.